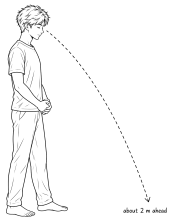
# Walking meditation

*A short straight path, walked slowly, with the note kept in time with the foot.*

## 1 · THE POSTURE

Stand with the feet close together, almost touching and level with each other. Neither foot is placed forward, and there is no gap between them. Clasp the hands, the right holding the left, either in front of the body or behind it. Keep the back straight.

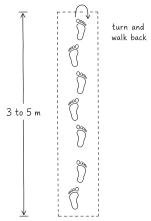
The eyes stay open. Let the gaze rest on the path about two metres ahead. Do not watch the feet, and do not look around the room. Looking down bends the neck and pulls the attention out of the body.




Eyes open and lowered, hands clasped, back straight.

## 2 · THE PATH

Use a straight path of three to five metres, indoors or outdoors. A path you know well is better than a new one, because there is less to look at. Walk to one end, turn, walk back, the same short path, over and over, for the whole session.

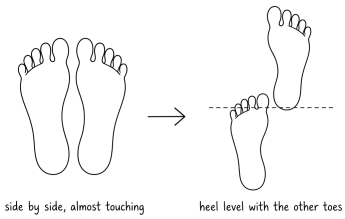



The same short path, walked back and forth.

## 3 · THE STEP

Move one foot forward by roughly one foot length, in a single smooth arc from beginning to end. The foot does not stop halfway and does not change direction in the middle. When it lands, the heel of the moving foot is level with the toes of the foot that stayed still.

Note each step in three parts, so the note runs alongside the movement rather than ahead of it or behind it: *step* as the foot leaves the floor, *ping* as it travels forward, *right* or *left* as it touches down. So the note is *stepping right*, then *stepping left*, on down the path. Go slowly enough that all three parts of the note have somewhere to land. If the note finishes before the foot does, you are walking too fast.




Side by side, almost touching, then heel level with the other toes.

### 4 · TURNING AT THE END

Do not simply swivel round. The turn is made in stages, a quarter turn at a time. Bring the back foot forward to stand beside the front one, noting *stopping* three times, then stand still, noting *standing* three times. Lift the right foot, turn it a quarter turn, place it down, noting *turning*. Bring the left foot beside it the same way, then the right foot again, then the left, which brings you to face back the way you came. Stand still once more, noting *standing*, then begin walking again, *stepping right* first.

### 5 · WHEN THE MIND WANDERS

If a thought or feeling comes and goes without pulling you off the path, keep walking and keep noting the steps. If it is strong enough to break the walking, stop where you are: bring the back foot forward, noting *stopping*, stand still, noting *standing*, then note whatever is there the same way as in sitting, *thinking*, *pain*, *angry*, *bored*, *happy*, and so on, until it fades. Then start walking again.

### 6 · HOW LONG, AND WHERE IT FITS

Walking comes before sitting, and the two are given the same length of time: ten minutes of walking, then ten minutes of sitting. Walking first is not an arbitrary order. Movement settles the body and gathers the attention while the eyes are still open, so the sitting starts from a mind that is already collected rather than from scratch. In a full session the order is prostration, then walking, then sitting, with the awareness carried unbroken from one to the next.

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**A common mistake.** Walking too slowly is as unhelpful as walking too fast. The pace is set by the note, not by an idea of how a meditator should look. Move at whatever speed lets you feel the whole of each step.

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### THE NOTES

*stepping right*

*stepping left*

*step · ping · right*

*stopping*

*standing*

*turning*

*thinking*

*pain*

*angry*

*bored*

*happy*

These instructions follow the meditation manual of Yuttadhammo Bhikkhu. The technique is the style of insight practice as taught by Ajahn Tong Sirimangalo, in which experience is noted silently and in plain language as it occurs.